



Mont Saint-Michel

A fortified medieval abbey that blends different styles in a spectacular setting

The small granite outcrop of Mont Saint-Michel lies off the coast of Normandy and fully becomes an island only at very high tides. The buildings and fortifications perched on top of the mount have a remarkable history that stretches back over 1,300 years.

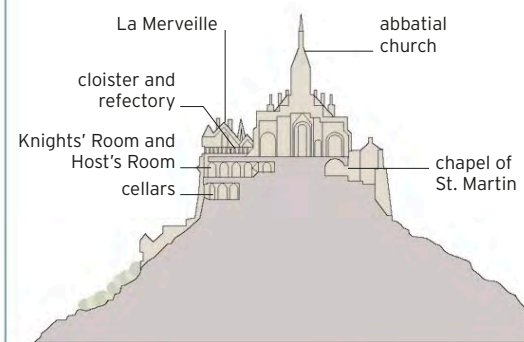
Mont Saint-Michel's first church was built in 709 CE. Pilgrims soon followed, risking their lives at low tide to reach the island. In 966, a Benedictine abbey was built and, as it grew, earlier structures were incorporated into a labyrinth of foundations, crypts, and staircases. In the 13th century, a three-story masterpiece of Norman Gothic architecture, known as La Merveille ("the Wonder"), was added, and a small township began to develop on the slope below the abbey.

Fort, prison, and monument

The island was fortified in 1256 and besieged several times during the Hundred Years' War (1337–1453) and French Wars of Religion (1562–1598). The abbey's fortunes waned after the Reformation, and it was made into a prison in the 19th century. The prison closed in 1863, and the mount was classified as an historic monument soon after. The creation of a causeway in 1874 made the journey to the island less treacherous. Monks returned to Mont Saint-Michel in 1966, and it became a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1979.

LA MERVEILLE

This view of the island shows the three stories of La Merveille, which reach a height of 115 ft (35 m). The levels reflected medieval ideas of hierarchy. Poor pilgrims would have eaten in the cellars, knights and important guests in the Knights' and Host's rooms, and—being spiritually nearest to heaven—the monks would have eaten in the refectory and relaxed in the cloisters.



Mont Saint-Michel was the **only place** in Normandy **not to fall** to the English in the **Hundred Years' War**

◀ CITADEL AT SEA

Silt deposition and land reclamation mean that the island, which was once 4 miles (7 km) out at sea, is now just 1.2 miles (2 km) from the shore and might eventually become part of the mainland.

▷ TOWN AND ABBEY

The abbey-church's tower and spire reach 558 ft (170 m) above the bay. Large ramparts protect the town at high tide.

